



Wallet for default

With Google's Wallet service improving by the day, phone carriers will pre-install the service on most upcoming phones. <http://dgit.in/DefWallet>



SteamVR incoming!

Seems like everyone is jumping on the VR bandwagon as Valve is getting ready to introduce SteamVR: http://dgit.in/Steam_VR

From the labs

The Disneyland case show us that even vaccinated kids can get measles, as the vaccine is only 97% effective i.e. about 97% of people who get two MMR doses will never get the measles disease. The flu vaccine, on the other hand, only reduces risk by 23%. Some vaccines are more effective than others, and you don't need to take them all. One Pew research survey showed that 86% of scientists think MMR vaccination should be made mandatory.

• Vaccination is a personal choice

Vaccination not only prevents you from getting the disease, it also prevents you from spreading it. Choosing to put yourself and your kids at risk is one thing, but you are also putting the rest of your community at risk. In this sense, vaccination is a social obligation. Even if everyone else vaccinated their children, no vaccine is 100% effective, so even vaccinated children are at risk from your unvaccinated child.

• Vaccines are profit driven

You get this a lot from conspiracy theorists - "Big Pharma wants to make you sick. Wake up sheeple!" It is true that major pharmaceutical companies that produce vaccines are hand in glove with the government. There is good reason not to completely trust either body. And vaccines are a for-profit product. But this does not mean that vaccine science is bad. Even you do not want to rely on evidence from these organisations, you can trust the peer reviewed scientific literature that shows that it works, and the demographic data that shows that it saves lives. Also, the consensus among scientists is that vaccination is safe, so being profit driven is not a relevant point.

Why do anti-vaxxers exist if they do not have valid points?

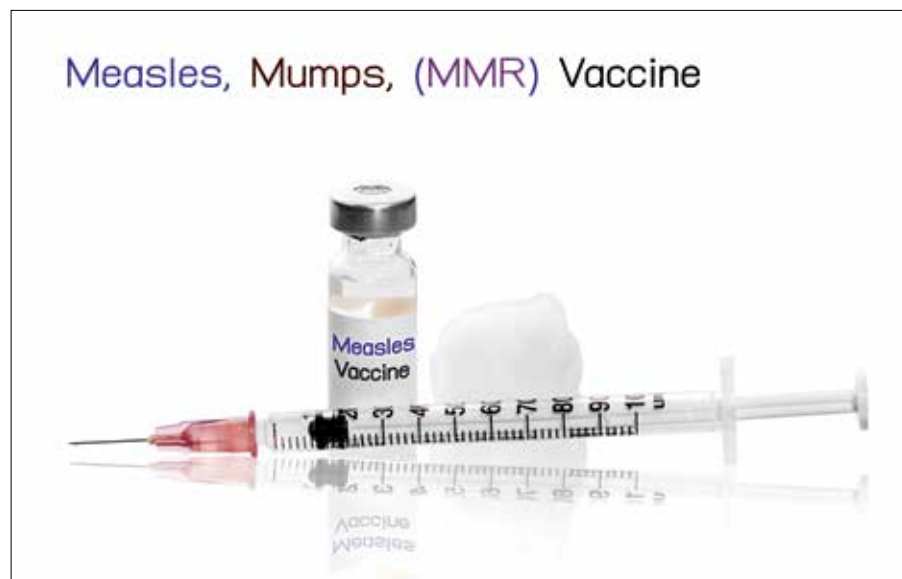
The answer to this question lies more with groupthink and a propensity towards narratives that feel right even if they are wrong.

True believers will always reject vaccines on some pretense or another. They will not let facts come in the way of their beliefs. Once anti-vaxxers choose to believe that there could be a link

between vaccination and autism (even though there isn't), nothing you can say will change their minds. This is a common psychological effect where even presenting evidence to the contrary will reinforce their incorrect beliefs.

For example, anti-vaxxers' response to the literature on autism and vaccination will only be to misrepresent the studies my focusing on minor flaws in the study designs, which does not negate the results. They just need one excuse to reject all the

senting voice, even if that dissenting voice is ridiculous and not evidence based. Media hype around bad scientific endeavours can have drastic effects on public health. In the UK, vaccination rates fell to 80% following the Lancet paper, low enough for measles to spread. In the US, the rate of unvaccinated children went up after 2000, with outbreaks in 2008, 2011 and 2014. Not all these outbreaks are linked to people being taken in by a talk show or a bad paper. Some are merely



The MMR vaccine could win a popularity contest. The syringe would not.

scientific literature and jump back into the safe arms of their narrative. To be fair, not all anti-vaxxers reject vaccination. Many of them believe in it, that it works, and think it should be administered, but also think that people should be more wary of government interference, or of possible side effects.

What convinces them to look at vaccination from this angle is anecdotal evidence that shows that some kids did change drastically after being vaccinated. It is easy to dismiss these events as anecdotal, but they merit further study. The problem is, no one has really investigated these cases much, and all the population wide data on vaccines and autism shows that vaccines are safe.

Unbalanced media reporting is also partly to blame. To appear balanced, media houses will ensure that their panels are filled with at least one dis-

examples of people relying on anecdotal evidence. They refused to vaccinate their children after they saw another child get sick after being vaccinated. This just underscores the reliance that people have on anecdotal evidence.

What you should do

Get vaccinated. Despite a minority of people displaying ant-vaccine sentiments, vaccines are proven to work across populations. They save lives, and most medical professionals encourage vaccination. Vaccines are 40 years old, they are cheap and they are getting better. The numbers for vaccine safety and efficacy hold up. About 1 in 5500 children may develop minor complications from being vaccinated. But 1 in 600 will get a disease without it. The math on this is clear. The benefit you gain on being vaccinated greatly exceeds the risk.